STAR Summer Research Program

(I) Student and Faculty Information

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(II) Background/Statement of Significance

"Game feel" is a term that can be described as the direct feeling experience in response to controlling what happens in a digital space. A successful game feel has the right combination of haptic feedback, controllability, and satisfying gameplay–"if a game designer has done his or her job correctly, the player will never notice the feel of a game. [...] it's an "invisible art" (Swink, 2008). Modern games tend to measure this feeling with responsiveness (West, 2008), or the time the game takes to respond–like a response in a conversations, it can come too early or too late. But what defines what is "too" anything? With these vague definitions in mind, the term "bad game feel" could be used to describe when the response to an input is unexpected, resulting in glitches or other errors. Specific examples of this could include lagging or slow-to-respond buttons, uncontrollable objects, or items and objects clipping in and out of each other defying real physics. The research being done in the Glitch Lab studies how these "errors" can be reframed, and how unintentional errors can be used intentionally to convey unique perspectives. For example, queerness is an identity, but it's also an experience. The conveyance of queerness in video games isn't always with queer character representation, it can also be evident in the structure of games made by queer creators. Queer experiences challenge the binary and societal expectations, therefore queer games have been known to do this by exploiting a game's rules, flaws, or glitches (Pelurson, 2020). Most innovative games are exploratory experiences. The research questions to be explored are these: How does one design games that have intentional flaws in their mechanics, which cause the player to question and think deeply about the experience they are interacting with? How does one design games to describe bad feelings?

(III) Project Design

This project consists of three phases: Research, Prototype, and Polish. The first phase is split into two tandem parts: scholarly research and learning the software. For scholarly research I will work towards understanding my role in these studies, reading and experiencing (in the case of games) existing content on queer theory in game

design, and experimenting with game feeling through learning and creating within Godot. I will start my reading with books of fundamentals such as *Game Feel,* by Steve Swink, and *Playing with Feelings* by Aubrey Anable, then move onto more detailed explorations of queer theory in games such as *Queer Game Studies,* an anthology, *Ugly Feelings*, by Sianne Ngai, and more. For the software learning piece, I will be learning Godot, an open source game engine, through online tutorials. Each tutorial creates a mini-game teaching a different skill, starting with 2d creation, and then moving onto 3d. The goal of this first phase is to orient myself to queer theory and the basic game design mechanics I will need for the rest of the project. The Prototype phase is application: I will create a prototype game in Godot to elaborate on and exhibit a specific aspect of bad game feel to reflect my experimentation and what I've learned. The goal of this phase is to apply theory to an interactive experience that showcases what I've learned. The Polish phase focuses on playtesting and presentation. Once a prototype game has been created, I will organize playtests of around ten to fifteen people to start iterative cycles of data collection and improvement on my prototype. In addition, I will document my research for future use in the field. At the conclusion of this project, I will have a playable game that exhibits experimental glitches as well as a comprehensive presentation.

(IV) Project Timeline

Week	Expectation
	Research
1-2	● Follow online tutorials to learn Godot and begin experimenting with in game mechanics ● Create small games in engine to test buildability and scope of project ● Read scholarly literature on queer game theory in order to research and orient to the research question
	Prototype
3-4	● Move on to more complex tutorials and establish main project idea ● Meet with mentor to showcase the work done in weeks 1 and 2, and show progress in learning Godot
5-6	● Establish a main project prototype that can begin to be playtested ● Document experimentation for main project as progress continues ● Work with mentor to connect main project to the main research question
	Polish

7-8	● Playtest current prototype via attending playtesting events within the greater Philly area ● Iterate on design as data is documented, continue to improve and debug ● 8/13 Abstract Submission Deadline
9	● Bring project to a finalized and polished state to be showcased ● Finalize STAR showcase poster ● 8/20 Poster Submission Deadline
10	● Prep presentation and present ideas, research, and project ● Finalize documentation of my STAR experience for future use in research and personal portfolio ● 8/27 STAR Showcase ● 8/28 STAR Ends

(V) Work Expectations

Location and Mentorship:
I will be working in person in URBN 243 at Drexel's Westphal College of Media Arts and Design. I will be directly mentored by Dr. Ari Gass.

Work Schedule:
I will work approximately 35 hours per week, with an hour long lunch break each day. Monday-Thursday will have a flexible schedule which will be detailed on a shared spreadsheet ahead of time for accountability purposes. Fridays, I will leave at 1pm. I will meet with my faculty mentor bi-weekly on Mondays and Thursdays for a formal check-in, and touch-base regularly for daily updates.

Absences:
If I need to request time off (for illness, appointments, or personal matters), I will notify my mentor at least 3 days in advance whenever possible. In cases of unexpected absence, I will notify my faculty mentor as soon as possible via discord.

(VI) Personal Statement

Game development is a multi-million dollar industry. This project is a leg of a much larger exploration of queer creation and decolonization regarding the video game industry, which is often very biased and stigmatized whether knowingly or unknowingly. Shedding light on these biases allows for conversations to start about why things are the way they are, and how they could be improved or changed, especially in the

creative fields. As a queer person myself, this project relates not just to me on a personal level, but on a community level as well. Not only am I able to explore how to express my own queerness through unconventional means in video games, but I'm creating an experience that will hopefully relate to others and shed light on queer and marginalized experiences. Through this project I hope to learn more about the field of queer theory in order to apply it to my future projects as a queer creator. I want to be able to hone my ideas into deconstructions of media to tell poignant stories and convey complex ideas.

(VII) Signatures of STAR Scholar and Mentor

Student Signature: _____ **Date:** 6/12/26

Mentor Signature: _____ **Date:** 6/12/26

Works Cited

Swink, Steve. 2008. *Game Feel : A Game Designer's Guide to Virtual Sensation*. Milton: Taylor & Francis Group. Accessed June 12, 2026. ProQuest Ebook Central.

Pelurson, Gaspard. 2020. *Queer Game Studies.* Edited by Karen Ross, Ingrid Bachmann, Valentina Cardo, Sujata Moorti, and Marco Scarcelli. *The International Encyclopedia of Gender, Media, and Communication*. Hoboken, NJ, USA: John Wiley & Sons, Inc. doi:10.1002/9781119429128.iegmc284.

West, Mick. 2008. *Measuring Responsiveness in Video Games.* Cowboy Programming cowboyprogramming.com